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Child and Youth Services

Inaugural Accreditation Guidelines



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INTRODUCTION



These Inaugural Accreditation Guidelines are used in conjunction with the appropriate standards manual to prepare for an Inaugural Accreditation survey. An organization seeking Inaugural One-Year Accreditation must order the current standards manual.

These Guidelines contain the following sections:

- An “Introduction” section that provides an overview of the Inaugural Accreditation process.
- A “Preparing for an Inaugural Accreditation Survey” section that provides guidance to help your organization plan and prepare for the survey.
- A “Standards” section that identifies the standards that will be applied on the survey. Details for each of the standards are contained in the standards manual.

The purpose of CARF’s Inaugural One-Year Accreditation is to provide an accreditation option that may satisfy regulatory or payer requirements for your organization, enabling it to timely obtain funding, licensure, and/or admissions. Before starting this process, your organization should verify that CARF Inaugural One-Year Accreditation (formerly known as “Preliminary Accreditation”) is accepted by the entity requiring accreditation.

To be eligible, any program to be included in the Inaugural Accreditation survey must have delivered services, if at all, for less than six months prior to the survey. An organization cannot have operational and non-operational programs on the same Inaugural survey. If your organization has both not-operational program(s) and operational program(s) providing services less than 6 months please contact your Resource Specialist for guidance.

An organization that earns Inaugural One-Year Accreditation must have a subsequent survey approximately 10–11 months after the Inaugural Accreditation survey. During the subsequent survey, special attention is given to changes made in response to recommendations from the Inaugural Accreditation survey as well as conformance to all applicable standards in the current standards manual. The subsequent survey may be a resurvey or supplemental survey, depending on the circumstances. If there are questions about the survey type, the organization should contact CARF to speak with their resource specialist.

An Inaugural One-Year Accreditation, once issued, is in effect as of the last day of the Inaugural Accreditation survey and remains in effect for 12 months or until notification of the outcome from the subsequent survey, whichever first occurs. The Inaugural One-Year Accreditation will expire if the subsequent survey is not timely applied for and completed within 12 months of the Inaugural Accreditation survey.

At the time of an Inaugural Accreditation survey, an organization should ensure that:

- Physical space for the program, if applicable, is in use or ready for service delivery.
- For programs where housing is a key component of the service (e.g. Community Housing, Residential Treatment), the organization must have at least one housing

location where the services are or will be delivered. The survey team must tour the housing location(s). If no housing locations are available for program delivery at the time of the survey, the survey team must contact CARF to drop the program from the survey.

- Policies, procedures, plans, processes, and protocols are in use or ready for implementation, as applicable.
- Key staff members are in place and recruitment plans/efforts are ongoing for hiring or contracting other necessary personnel.

Steps to Inaugural Accreditation

STEP 1: Consult with source requiring accreditation

Determine the acceptability of Inaugural One-Year Accreditation in consultation with your funding, licensing, or referral source(s).

STEP 2: Consult with a CARF resource specialist

An organization contacts CARF, and a resource specialist is designated to provide guidance and technical assistance.

- It is important to make this contact early in the process. The resource specialist is available to answer questions in preparation for a survey and throughout the term of accreditation.
- The resource specialist provides the organization access to Customer Connect (customerconnect.carf.org), CARF's secure website for managing the accreditation relationship, including transmitting documents and maintaining ongoing communication. As documents are posted to Customer Connect, an email is sent to the individual identified as the organization's Survey Key Contact. Organizations should use Customer Connect regularly to view accreditation- and survey-related documents and to keep CARF informed of organizational changes, including the name or email address of the key contact person.
- The organization orders the appropriate standards manual in which its program(s)/service(s) best fit, based on consultation with the resource specialist. Visit www.carf.org/catalog. (Please refer to the section *Preparing for an Inaugural Accreditation Survey* for information on available formats and other publications that may also be helpful.)
- Direct any questions about these Inaugural Accreditation Guidelines and the standards manual to the designated resource specialist. The standards applied on an Inaugural Accreditation survey are a subset of the standards in the current standards manual.

STEP 3: Conduct a self-evaluation

The organization conducts a self-study and evaluation of its conformance to the standards using the standards manual and the Inaugural Accreditation applicable standards identified in these Guidelines.

- The self-evaluation should include conformance to all applicable standards. For standards where the direct provision of services is a prerequisite, ensure that all policies, procedures, plans, and processes exist and are in use or ready for imple-

mentation, as applicable. (See the section *Preparing for an Inaugural Accreditation Survey* for more information on how to demonstrate conformance to the standards for an Inaugural Accreditation survey.)

- Review the *Accreditation Policies and Procedures* section in the standards manual to ensure that you understand the accreditation process and requirements, including CARF's Accreditation Conditions.

NOTE: *Accreditation Condition 1 is waived for Inaugural Accreditation but is in effect for the subsequent survey.*

STEP 4: Submit the survey application

The organization submits the survey application via Customer Connect (customerconnect.carf.org).

- The survey application requests detailed information about leadership, program(s)/service(s) that the organization is seeking to accredit, and the current or future service delivery location(s). All sections of the application should be completed based on information known at the time of submission
- The Inaugural Accreditation survey will occur approximately three to four months after submission of the survey application and the nonrefundable application fee. When completing the application, the organization should make best efforts to select a survey timeframe that ends before the program(s) will deliver services for six months, if at all. (If your organization seeks an Inaugural Accreditation survey to be conducted at the same time as another CARF survey, it may be necessary to submit the Inaugural Accreditation survey application in accordance with the survey timeframes published in the Accreditation Policies and Procedures section of the applicable standards manual or at another time. In such event, contact the designated resource specialist to determine the appropriate application submission deadline and survey timeframe.)
- The submission of the completed survey application indicates the organization's desire for the survey and commitment to a subsequent survey, as well as its agreement to all terms and conditions contained therein.
- If any information provided in the survey application changes after submission, the organization must notify CARF in writing immediately.

STEP 5: CARF invoices for the survey fee

After reviewing all information in the survey application, CARF invoices the organization for the survey fee.

- The survey fee is based on the number of surveyors and days needed to complete the survey.
- The survey fee invoice is posted to Customer Connect and an email notification is sent to the organization's Survey Key Contact.
- Scheduling of the survey begins upon payment of at least half of the fee within 10 days of the invoice date; therefore, any delay in payment will result in a change to a later survey timeframe. Any changes in problem dates must be communicated in writing to CARF by this time. (Note that, if late payment delays the survey timeframe beyond six months of service delivery, the organization is ineligible for Inaugural Accreditation.)

STEP 6: CARF selects the survey team

CARF selects a survey team with the appropriate expertise.

- Surveyors are selected by matching their expertise, field experience, and other relevant factors with the organization's unique characteristics.
- CARF makes best efforts to notify the organization of the names of team members and the dates of the survey at least 30 days before the survey.

STEP 7: The survey team conducts the survey

The survey team assesses the organization's conformance to all applicable standards through observation of services (if applicable), interviews with organizational leadership and other stakeholders (including persons served, if applicable), and review of documentation.

- Surveyors also provide consultation to the organization.
- The organization is informed of the survey team's findings related to the standards at an exit conference before the team concludes the survey. The survey team submits its findings to CARF, but the team does not determine the accreditation decision.

STEP 8: CARF issues the accreditation decision

CARF conducts an expedited review of the survey findings and determines whether an Inaugural One-Year Accreditation is appropriate.

- Approximately two weeks after the survey, the organization is notified of the accreditation decision and receives a written report.
- Within 60 days of issuing an Inaugural One-Year Accreditation decision, the organization receives a certificate of accreditation that lists the program(s)/service(s) included in the accreditation.
- If Inaugural One-Year Accreditation is not issued, the organization is deemed "not accredited."

STEP 9: Submit a Quality Improvement Plan

Within 90 days after notification of accreditation, the organization fulfills an accreditation condition by submitting to CARF a Quality Improvement Plan (QIP) outlining the actions that have been or will be taken in response to the recommendations identified in the report.

STEP 10: Prepare for the subsequent survey

The organization prepares for the subsequent survey by addressing all applicable standards in the standards manual and taking actions in response to recommendations in the report from the Inaugural Accreditation survey.

- The organization should contact its CARF resource specialist with any questions that arise during preparation for the subsequent survey.
- CARF standards manuals go into effect on July 1 of each year. Surveys are conducted using the standards manual that is in effect at the time of the survey. Based on survey timeframes, the subsequent survey will likely be conducted under a newer version of the standards manual from that used for the Inaugural Accreditation survey. Organizations can contact their resource specialist to request a complimentary electronic copy of the new standards manual for use in preparing if the

timeframe for the subsequent survey will be after July 1. (Refer to the “Survey Timeframes” chart to determine if the subsequent survey will occur in a new standards manual year.)

STEP 11: Apply for and complete the subsequent survey

The process of applying for and completing the subsequent survey and maintaining CARF accreditation is explained in detail in the “Accreditation Policies and Procedures” section of the standards manual.

- There is no application fee for the subsequent survey.
- Scheduling of the subsequent survey begins upon payment of at least half of the fee.

Survey Timeframes

The Inaugural Accreditation survey application should be submitted to CARF when the organization is ready for its survey dates to be established, keeping in mind that **the survey must occur prior to six months of service delivery.**

Inaugural Accreditation Survey Application Received by*	Inaugural Accreditation Survey Timeframe**	Subsequent Survey Timeframe
April 30	July/August	July/August
May 31	August/September	July/August
June 30	September/October	August/September
July 31	October/November	September/October
August 31	November/December	October/November
September 30	December/January	November/December
October 31	January/February	December/January
November 30	February/March	January/February
December 31	March/April	February/March
January 31	April/May	March/April
February 28/29	May/June	April/May
March 31	June	May/June
*These Inaugural Accreditation Survey Application Received By dates are not applicable to organizations that seek an Inaugural Accreditation survey to be conducted at the same time as another CARF survey. In such event, it may be necessary to submit the Inaugural Accreditation survey application in accordance with the survey timeframes published in the “Accreditation Policies and Procedures” section of the applicable standards manual or at another time. In such event, contact the designated resource specialist to determine the appropriate application submission deadline and survey timeframe. ** Must be prior to six months of service delivery to any persons.		

NOTE: Actual survey timeframes are assigned by CARF based upon surveyor availability.

PREPARING FOR AN INAUGURAL ACCREDITATION SURVEY



This section provides guidance on how to demonstrate conformance to applicable standards at the level expected at the time of an Inaugural Accreditation survey. This information is supplemental to the CARF standards manual and must be used in conjunction with the manual. You should begin using the manual as early as possible in the preparation process. The manual includes intent statements and examples for many of the standards, which are provided to help you understand and implement the standards. The standards manual also includes a glossary that defines certain terms as they are used in the CARF manuals and Appendices that identify standards with specific requirements related to documentation, timelines, and education and training. If you have questions at any point in your survey preparation process about how to apply the standards or how you can demonstrate conformance to any of the standards, contact your CARF resource specialist for guidance.

Survey preparation tools available from CARF

You may also want to consider the following optional survey preparation tools, which are available for purchase from CARF through the Online Store (www.carf.org/catalog):

- The *Survey Preparation Workbook* includes detailed survey preparation questions for each standard and additional resources to help an organization prepare for its survey.
- The *Electronic Standards Manual with Survey Preparation Workbook* includes bookmarked PDF files of the standards manual and the survey preparation workbook along with a set of rich text files (.rtf) that integrate the standards from the manual with the survey preparation questions from the workbook. The .rtf files can be opened by any word processing program and text can be entered into them. You can print or save the files to a computer hard drive.
- The *Accreditation Sourcebook* is a nontechnical, reader-friendly guide to the CARF accreditation process that provides a comprehensive overview of what accreditation is all about. It includes information about the application process, survey scheduling, sample survey preparation timetables, and more.

Survey planning

At the time of the Inaugural Accreditation survey:

- Key staff members should be in place and the organization should be actively recruiting and hiring or contracting other necessary personnel.
- Training should be complete for all personnel actively working with persons served. Otherwise, training should be complete, in process, or planned for all personnel to complete before they begin working with persons served.

- The physical space for the program, if applicable, should be finished and in use or ready for service delivery.
- Policies, procedures, plans, processes, and protocols should be developed and in use or ready for implementation, as applicable. See Appendices A, B, and C from the full standards manual.

During the Inaugural Accreditation survey, the survey team will:

- Tour the organization and the physical space for the program, if applicable, to determine conformance to standards related to the physical plant, health and safety, accessibility, etc.
- If service delivery has commenced, observe services and review records of persons served.
- Review documentation to verify conformance with standards that require plans, policies, or written procedures.
 - Examples of documents that may be used to demonstrate conformance include governing documents, planning documents, policies and procedures, inspection reports, checklists, forms that will be used, and brochures or other information about the program that are or will be provided to persons served and/or the public.
 - It is not necessary to make copies of the same document for each standard requiring that document. The surveyors will note all standards that each document addresses.
- Conduct interviews with leadership and other stakeholders (including persons served, if applicable) to determine how the organization is using and/or plans to meet the applicable standards.
 - Before the survey you should decide who are the best persons in your organization to be interviewed regarding certain topics and responsibilities.
 - Be prepared to explain to the survey team how your program design and planning have incorporated and will continue to consider the needs and input of persons served.

Demonstrating conformance to the standards

During the Inaugural Accreditation survey, your organization should be able to demonstrate conformance to all applicable standards to the extent possible, recognizing that conformance to some standards may not be possible prior to service delivery.

To demonstrate conformance to the standards toward Inaugural One-Year Accreditation, following are some guides on what is required for an organization to show.

- If a standard requires written procedures, the written procedures should be complete, address all areas of the standard, and be in use or ready for implementation, as applicable.
- If a standard requires a policy, the policy should be complete, address all areas of the standard, and be in use or ready for implementation, as applicable. By CARF definition, a policy must be in writing.
- If a standard requires a plan, the plan must address all areas of the standard. By CARF definition, a plan must be in writing.

- Forms that are or will be used can be considered to demonstrate conformance to some standards.
- For standards that do not require anything in writing, be prepared to explain how you have implemented the standard in your planning and program design, and how you meet or plan to meet the standard in service delivery, as applicable.
- If a standard requires an action or activity that cannot be fully demonstrated before you begin delivering services to persons served, be prepared to explain or show the survey team how you will conform to the standard.
- Personnel should be able to discuss and show that they are familiar with and understand how to implement the CARF standards as applicable to their jobs. If service delivery has commenced, personnel should also be able to provide evidence of implementation.
- See Appendices A, B, and C in the standards manual.
- See the *Glossary* in full standards manual for definitions of terms.

If you have questions at any point in your survey preparation about how to apply the standards or how you can demonstrate conformance to any of the standards, contact your CARF resource specialist for guidance.

STANDARDS



This section identifies the standards that are applied on an Inaugural Accreditation survey. Use either **Subsection A** or **Subsection B** based on the following:

- Use **Subsection A. Not Operational** if service delivery will commence **after** the survey (i.e., the program **will NOT** be operational during the survey).
- Use **Subsection B. Operational** if service delivery will commence **prior to** the survey (i.e., the program **will** be operational during the survey).

The lists in Subsections A and B refer to standards in the *2026 Child and Youth Services Standards Manual*. The standard numbers listed include all subparts of the standard, except where noted.

Refer to the previous section for additional survey preparation guidelines and information. Please contact your CARF resource specialist with any questions.

A. Not Operational

This subsection identifies the standards in the *2026 Child and Youth Services Standards Manual* that **are applied** on an Inaugural Accreditation survey for programs that **will NOT** commence service delivery until **after** the survey. For standards where only some subparts of the standard are identified as applicable, the applicable subparts are specified.

Section 1. ASPIRE to Excellence[®]

- 1.A. Leadership
 - Standard 1.
 - Standard 2.
 - Standard 3., elements a., e., f., h., i., j., l., n., and o.
 - Standard 5.a.
 - Standard 6., elements a.–c.
 - Standard 7.
 - Standard 8.
 - Standard 9. (if the organization directly solicits charitable financial support in connection with any program seeking accreditation)
- 1.C. Strategic Planning
 - Standard 1., elements a.–l.(2)(d)
 - Standard 2., elements a.(2), b., and c.
- 1.D. Input from Persons Served and Other Stakeholders
 - Standard 1., elements b.(2) and c.

- 1.E. Legal Requirements
 - Standards 1.–3.
- 1.F. Financial Planning and Management
 - Standard 1.b.
 - Standard 2., elements a., b.(1), and b.(3)
 - Standard 5.a.
 - Standard 7.a.
- 1.G. Risk Management
 - Standard 1., elements a.(1)–(3)
 - Standard 2., elements b. and c.
 - Standard 3.
 - Standard 4.
- 1.H. Health and Safety
 - Standards 1. and 2.
 - Standard 4.a.
 - Standards 5. and 6.
 - Standard 8.
 - Standard 9., elements b.(2) and b.(3)
 - Standard 10.
 - Standard 12.
 - Standards 14.–16.
- 1.I. Workforce Development and Management
 - Standards 1.–3.
 - Standard 4., elements b., d., and e.
 - Standards 5. and 6.
 - Standard 7.d.(1)
 - Standard 8., elements a.–c.
 - Standards 9.–11.
 - Standard 13., elements a., b., and c.(1)
- 1.J. Rights of Persons Served
 - Standard 1.
 - Standard 2., elements a.(1), a.(2), and b.
 - Standard 3., elements a. and b.
- 1.K. Accessibility
 - Standard 1.
 - Standard 2.a.–b.(2).

- 1.L. Performance Management and Measurement
 - Standard 1.
 - Standard 2., elements a.(2) and b.–g.
 - Standard 3.a.

Section 2. General Program Standards

NOTE: *Assessment tools to be used by the program and a mock chart containing forms for use with or by the persons served should be available.*

- Section 2.A. Program/Service Structure
 - Standard 1.a.
 - Standards 2. and 3.
 - Standard 5.
 - Standards 8.–17.
 - Standards 19.–23.
 - Standards 27.–29.
 - Standard 31.
 - Standard 38.
 - Standard 40.
 - Standards 43. and 44.
- Section 2.B. Screening and Access to Services
 - Standard 1.
 - Standard 7.
 - Standard 11.
- Section 2.C. Individualized Planning
 - Standard 1. and 2.
- Section 2.D. Transition/Discharge
 - Standard 1.
- Section 2.E. Medication Use
 - Standard 1.
 - Standard 3. (if intend to physically control medications)
 - Standards 4.–8. (if intend to prescribe, control, or administer medications)
- Section 2.F. Promoting Nonviolent Practices
 - Standards 1. and 2.
 - Standards 3.–5.,
 - Standards 7. and 8.
 - Standard 10. (if intend to use seclusion or restraint)

- Section 2.G. Records of the Persons Served

- Standard 1.a.
- Standards 2.–4.
- Standard 6.

- Section 2.H. Quality Records Management

- Standard 4.

NOTE: *A process for systematic records review should be available.*

- Section 2.I. Service Delivery Using Information and Communication Technologies

- Standards 1. and 2.

Sections 3.–5. Core Program Standards, Core Residential Program Standards, and Specialty Designation Standards

All standards in Sections 3.–5. are applicable to the extent possible.

B. Operational

This subsection identifies the standards in the *2026 Child and Youth Services Standards Manual* that **are NOT applied** on an Inaugural Accreditation survey for programs that **will** commence service delivery **prior to** the survey. For standards where only some subparts of the standard are identified, the inapplicable subparts are specified (and the remainder of the standard **IS applicable**).

Section 1. ASPIRE to Excellence[®]

- 1.A. Leadership
 - Standard 5., elements b. and c.
- 1.C. Strategic Planning
 - Standard 1.m.
 - Standard 2., elements d. and e.
- 1.F. Financial Planning and Management
 - Standard 8.
- 1.G. Risk Management
 - Standard 1.b.
 - Standard 2.a.
 - Standard 5.
- 1.H. Health and Safety
 - Standard 4.b.
 - Standard 11.
 - Standard 13.l.
- 1.J. Rights of Persons Served
 - Standard 2.a.(3)
 - Standard 4.
- 1.K. Accessibility
 - Standard 2., elements c. and d.
 - Standard 3., elements b. and c.
- 1.L. Performance Management and Measurement
 - Standard 3., elements b. and c.
- 1.M. Performance Improvement
 - Standards 1.–4.

Section 2. General Program Standards

NOTE: *Assessment tools to be used by the program and a mock chart containing forms for use with or by the persons served should be available.*

B. OPERATIONAL

- 2.A. Program/Service Structure
 - Standard 1., elements c. and d.
 - Standard 31.b.
- 2.E. Medication Use
 - Standard 1.a.(2)
 - Standard 9.
- 2.F. Promoting Nonviolent Practices
 - Standards 3, elements c. and d.
 - Standard 11.



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